

India's Proposed BRICS Reform Roadmap



For Prelims: United Nations Secretary-General , UN Security Council , Bretton Woods institutions , Artificial Intelligence , Critical minerals , G7 , SWIFT messaging system

For Mains: Reform of Global Governance Institutions, Crisis of Multilateralism, India's Role in Reformed Multilateralism

Source: TH

Why in News?

During the **18 th BRICS Summit** held in New Delhi (September 2026), the Indian Prime Minister urged BRICS leaders to formulate **10 global governance reform proposals** . These proposals are intended to be developed into a comprehensive **BRICS Reform Roadmap** by the next summit in 2027.

- Concurrently, the **United Nations Secretary-General** highlighted that "**distorted power relations in the world make the Security Council non-operational**," reaffirming the urgent need to address the democratic deficit in global multilateral institutions.

Summary

- India's proposed BRICS Reform Roadmap** seeks to reform global institutions through **Representation, Responsiveness and inclusive rule-making** , giving the Global South a greater role in decision-making.
- It aims to address challenges such as **UNSC underrepresentation, financial governance imbalances, WTO paralysis and exclusion from emerging-technology rule-making** , making global governance more inclusive and equitable.

What are the Key Highlights of India's Proposed BRICS Reform Roadmap?

- **From "Rule-Takers to Rule-Shapers":** India emphasized the need to dismantle the current global governance structure (described as a **"pyramid of privilege"**) and transform it into a **"platform of partnership."**
 - This is crucial as the **Global South** is at the forefront of global crises but remains excluded from key decision-making.
- **Consensus-Based Approach:** India highlighted that BRICS seeks to advance global reforms through dialogue, consensus and cooperation, not as a counter-bloc against any country.
- **The Three Pillars (The 3Rs):** The 10 proposed reform measures will focus on three broad areas — Representation, Responsiveness and Rule-making.
 - **Representation:** The reform of the **UN Security Council (UNSC)** can no longer be delayed. Text-based negotiations for expanding the UNSC must be linked to a definite timeline and clear outcomes.
 - Furthermore, the voting power and leadership roles in **Bretton Woods institutions (IMF, World Bank)** must reflect contemporary economic realities, granting proportional influence to emerging engines of global growth.
 - **Responsiveness:** Global institutions must improve the speed, scale, and last-mile impact of their crisis responses.
 - As a practical example, India proposed establishing a **Seafarers' Emergency Support Network** to connect maritime authorities and missions, ensuring rapid distress alerts, medical aid, and evacuation for maritime workers.
- **Rule-Making in Emerging Technologies:** Equal participation is vital in framing global regulations for future domains such as **Artificial Intelligence (AI)** , **cyberspace, outer space, biotechnology, and critical minerals** .
 - To achieve this, BRICS aims to provide young diplomats from the Global South with legal, practical, and negotiation expertise to actively shape these future rules.
- **BRICS Continuity and Implementation Mechanism:** To prevent institutional momentum from stalling due to annual Presidency rotations, India proposed creating a formal mechanism utilizing the **BRICS Troika (current, previous, and incoming chairs)** and a secure digital repository to systematically track initiatives, deadlines, and implementation statuses.

Significance

- **Empowering the Global South:** By proposing a concrete, 10-point roadmap, India leverages the expanded 11-member BRICS grouping (**representing ~40% of global GDP and nearly half the world's population**) as a collective counterweight to Western-dominated forums like the **G7**.
 - It ensures the Global South's demographic and economic weight translates into actual global policy impact.
- **Future-Proofing Governance:** By expanding the scope of reform beyond traditional bodies (like the UN) to frontier technologies (AI, cyberspace), the roadmap ensures that developing nations are not locked out of the regulatory frameworks that will define the 21st-century global economy.
- **Transitioning from Critique to Constructive Action:** As BRICS celebrates its 20th anniversary, this roadmap signifies the bloc's **"coming of age"**.
 - It shifts the grouping's focus from merely critiquing the outdated Western institutional architecture to **actively providing constructive, structured, and alternative frameworks** for equitable global governance.

What are the Impediments to Global Governance

Institutions?

- **Outdated Representation in the UNSC:** The UNSC largely reflects the geopolitical realities of the **post-World War II era** . The absolute exclusion of entire continents impacts the body's global legitimacy.
 - For instance, Africa and Latin America have zero permanent representation. This has prompted coalitions like the **G4 nations (India, Brazil, Germany, Japan)** to strongly advocate for permanent seats, while the **Sirte Declaration and Ezulwini Consensus** outline the unified African demand for two permanent seats to reflect contemporary demographics.
- **Conventions in Global Finance:** The Bretton Woods Institutions operate on an unwritten agreement reserving the **World Bank Presidency for an American** and the **IMF leadership for a European** . Existing quota formulas fail to reflect the economic weight of emerging economies like India, skewing global financial decision-making.
- **Constraints of the Veto Power:** The frequent use of veto power by the **Permanent Five (P5)** to shield strategic allies has paralyzed the UNSC. Repeated vetoes by **Russia regarding Ukraine** and the **US regarding Gaza** highlight its inability to maintain international peace.
- **Inconsistencies in the Application of Norms:** Multilateralism suffers from a trust deficit due to the selective application of international law, visible in the unequal enforcement of frameworks like the **Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT)** based on geopolitical alliances rather than universal rules.
- **Over-reliance on Earmarked Funding:** A shift toward conditional, voluntary contributions from wealthy donor nations and philanthropies forces UN bodies to prioritize donor interests over universal mandates. Currently, over **80% of the WHO's budget** relies on such earmarked funding.
- **Challenges in the WTO Dispute Mechanism:** The **World Trade Organization's** dispute settlement mechanism remains crippled because the **US has systematically blocked appointments to the Appellate Body** since 2019, allowing nations to violate trade rules without facing enforcement.
- **Unilateral Trade and Environmental Measures:** Developed nations increasingly bypass multilateral consensus through unilateral measures like the **EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM)** or trade-distorting domestic subsidies like the **US Inflation Reduction Act (IRA)** , which disproportionately burden developing economies.
- **Instrumentalization of Financial Systems:** The geopolitical weaponization of global financial infrastructure such as expulsions from the **SWIFT messaging system** and the freezing of sovereign central bank reserves erodes trust in its neutrality and accelerates de-dollarization efforts among BRICS nations.
- **Rise of "Minilateralism" and Fragmented Tech Governance:** Rule-making for emerging domains is increasingly monopolized by exclusive Western coalitions like the **G7 Hiroshima AI Process** , locking the Global South out of global technological governance.
- **Differing Regional Perspectives:** Reform efforts are often stalled by internal fragmentation among developing nations. Coalitions like the **"Uniting for Consensus" (Coffee Club)** actively oppose the creation of new permanent UNSC seats to block regional rivals (e.g., Pakistan opposing India's bid).
- **Policy Volatility & Multilateral Disengagement:** **US withdrawal from the Paris Agreement** weakens global climate leadership, disrupts climate finance through mechanisms like the **Green Climate Fund and Loss and Damage Fund (LDF)** , and discourages countries from adhering to their **Nationally Determined Contributions** .
- **Funding Boycotts:** Geopolitical disputes, including **US and Israeli withdrawals from UNESCO** , have reduced funding, weakened its operations, and undermined its work in **education, science, and cultural preservation** .

Way Forward

- **Transitioning to Text-Based Negotiations:** The UN General Assembly must move beyond open-ended debates within the Intergovernmental Negotiations (IGN) framework and commit to **time-bound, text-based negotiations to formalize the expansion of the UNSC** in both permanent and non-permanent categories.
- **Democratizing the Financial Architecture:** There is an urgent need to expedite **quota realignments at the IMF and World Bank** to accurately reflect the current GDP and purchasing power of emerging economies.
 - Additionally, leadership appointments must transition to a transparent, merit-based system, discarding outdated geographical monopolies.
- **Restoring the Multilateral Trade Order:** The international community must prioritize the revival of the **WTO's two-tier dispute settlement mechanism by breaking the deadlock on Appellate Body appointments**, while actively safeguarding **Special and Differential Treatment (S&DT)** provisions for developing nations.
- **Forging a Unified Global South Consensus:** To overcome internal fragmentation platforms like **BRICS, the African Union, and the G20** must build diplomatic bridges to present a cohesive, unified front on institutional reforms, climate justice, and equitable trade.
- **Proactive Norm-Setting in Frontier Technologies:** The Global South must operationalize the **BRICS tech-diplomacy initiatives to co-create universal**, UN-backed regulatory frameworks for AI, outer space, and critical minerals. This will ensure developing nations transition from passive consumers to active architects of future global norms.

Conclusion

The **BRICS Reform Roadmap** seeks to make global governance more **representative, inclusive and equitable** by enabling the Global South to move from **“rule-takers” to “rule-shapers”** and transform the existing **“pyramid of privilege” into a “platform of partnership.”**

Drishti Mains Question:

“Representation without responsiveness cannot ensure legitimacy of global institutions.” Discuss in the context of India’s proposed 3Rs framework.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What are the three pillars of India's proposed BRICS Reform Roadmap?

The three pillars are **Representation, Responsiveness and Rule-Making in Emerging Technologies**, aimed at giving the Global South greater influence in global governance.

2. Why is UNSC reform important for the Global South?

The UNSC reflects the **post-World War II power structure**, with inadequate representation of Africa, Latin America and other developing regions.

3. What is the significance of the Ezulwini Consensus?

The **Ezulwini Consensus** represents Africa's common position seeking **two permanent and additional non-permanent seats** on a reformed UNSC.

4. What are the major challenges to global governance reform?

Key challenges include **veto power, outdated representation, geopolitical rivalries, institutional fragmentation, selective application of norms and divisions among developing countries**.

5. How can the Global South become "rule-shapers"?

Developing countries can strengthen **collective diplomacy through BRICS, G20 and the African Union**, while actively participating in rule-making on finance, trade, climate and emerging technologies.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/JqHhjWrDogI](https://www.youtube.com/embed/JqHhjWrDogI)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. With reference to the "United Nations Credentials Committee", consider the following statements: (2022)

1. It is a committee set up by the UN Security Council and works under its supervision.
2. It traditionally meets in March, June and September every year
3. It assesses the credentials of all UN members before submitting a report to the General Assembly for approval.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 3 only
- (b) 1 and 3
- (c) 2 and 3
- (d) 1 and 2

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q. The reform process in the United Nations remains unresolved because of the delicate imbalance of East and West and entanglement of the USA vs. Russo-Chinese alliance. Examine and critically evaluate the East-West policy confrontations in this regard. (2025).

India's Path to Blue Skies



Source: PIB

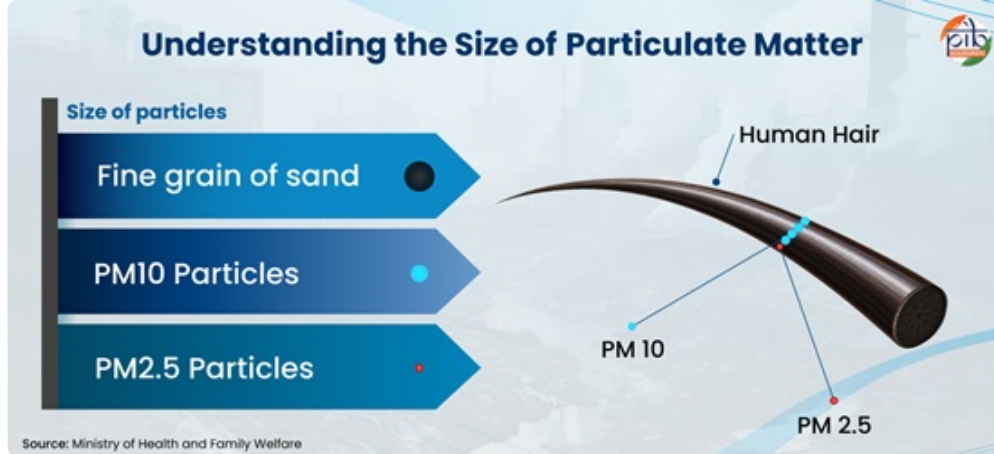
Why in News?

Recently, the **International Day of Clean Air for Blue Skies (7 September)** was observed globally to raise awareness and promote action against air pollution. Designated by the **United Nations General Assembly in 2019**, the day highlights global efforts to improve air quality.

- India observes it as **Swachh Vayu Diwas**, aligning international commitments with national clean-air initiatives.

What is Air Pollution?

- **About:** Air pollution refers to the accumulation of harmful substances in the atmosphere at levels that adversely affect **human health and the environment**. These pollutants may exist as **gases, liquid droplets or solid particles** and originate from both **natural processes and human activities** such as transport, industries, construction and burning.
- **Significance:** Clean air is fundamental to human health, environmental sustainability and economic well-being, making air pollution control a key global priority.
- **Particulate Matter (PM):** **Particulate Matter (PM)** is a major air pollutant consisting of tiny solid or liquid particles suspended in the atmosphere. It is classified mainly into:
 - **PM10:** Particles with a diameter of **10 micrometres or less**.
 - **PM2.5:** Fine particles with a diameter of **2.5 micrometres or less**, capable of penetrating deep into the respiratory system and, in some cases, entering the bloodstream.
- **Health Significance:** Due to their extremely small size, **PM2.5 particles pose greater health risks** by reaching deeper lung tissues and increasing the risk of respiratory and cardiovascular diseases, making particulate pollution control essential for **clean air and healthier communities**.



Air Pollution Monitoring Systems

System	Purpose and Features
Continuous Ambient Air Quality Monitoring System (CAAQMS)	Provides automated, real-time monitoring of pollutants such as PM_{2.5}, PM₁₀, SO₂, NO_x, CO, O₃ and NH₃ to support timely air-quality assessment.
Ambient Air Quality Monitoring System (AAQMS)	Includes both manual and automated monitoring systems . Manual monitoring involves 24-hour sampling and laboratory analysis, while automated systems continuously measure pollutants and meteorological parameters.
Online Continuous Emission Monitoring System (OCEMS)	Installed in highly polluting industries to continuously monitor emissions (and applicable discharges) and transmit data to regulatory authorities for compliance with prescribed environmental standards.

What are India's Initiatives to Mitigate Air Pollution?

National Air Quality Monitoring Programme (NAMP)

- **About:** The **National Ambient Air Quality Monitoring Programme (NAAQM)**, later renamed **NAMP**, was initiated by the **Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB)** to assess ambient air quality, monitor pollution trends, identify violations of air quality standards and evaluate associated health risks.
- **Monitoring Network:** As of **March 2026**, India's air-quality monitoring network consists of **1,646 stations across 603 cities in 28 States and 7 Union Territories**, including:
 - **Manual monitoring stations:** Collect air samples periodically for laboratory analysis.
 - **Continuous Ambient Air Quality Monitoring Stations (CAAQMS):** Provide real-time air quality data.

- **Citizen Access and Transparency:** The **SAMEER mobile application and web portal** provide near real-time **Air Quality Index (AQI)** information for more than **292 cities** , while grievance portals in **NCAP cities** promote public participation in pollution control.

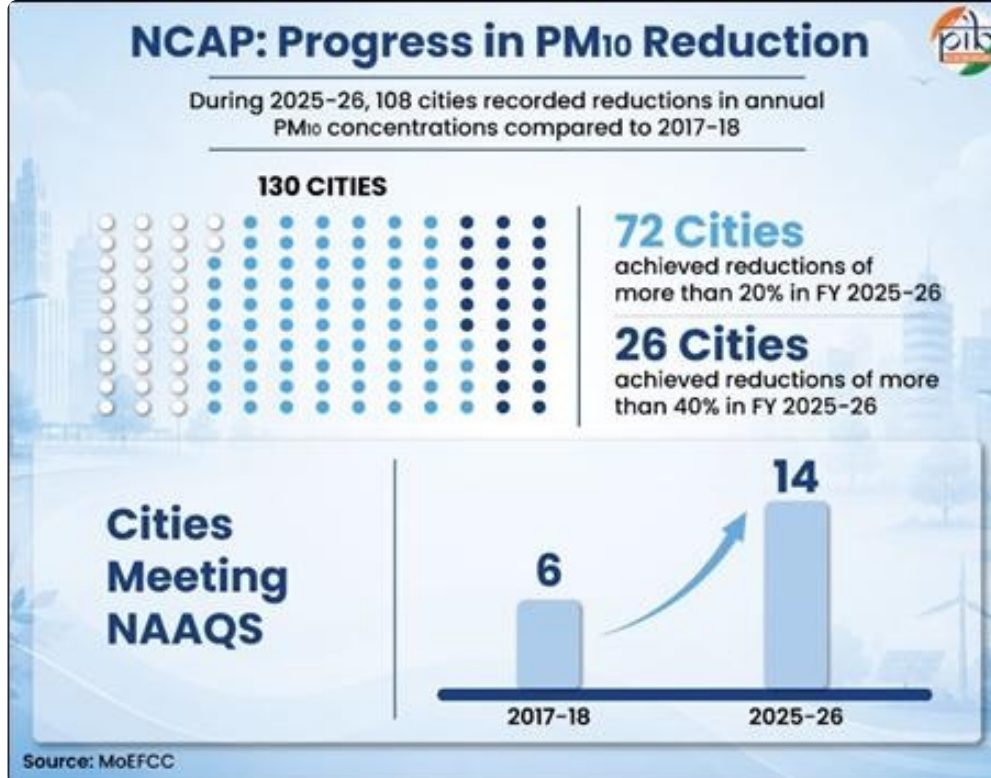
Air Quality Index (AQI)

- **About:** AQI is a public communication tool that simplifies air quality information by categorising pollution levels based on pollutant concentration and health impacts.
- **Pollutants Covered:** AQI is calculated using **eight pollutants** : PM_{2.5}, PM₁₀, Nitrogen Dioxide (NO₂), Sulphur Dioxide (SO₂), Carbon Monoxide (CO), Ozone (O₃), Ammonia (NH₃) and Lead (Pb).

AQI Category	AQI Range
Good	0-50
Satisfactory	51-100
Moderate	101-200
Poor	201-300
Very Poor	301-400
Severe	401-500

National Clean Air Programme (NCAP)

- **Launch:** The **National Clean Air Programme (NCAP)** was launched in **2019** to address urban air pollution through a mission-mode approach covering **130 cities** .
- **Approach:** NCAP promotes **source-specific pollution control measures** through city, state and national-level clean air action plans involving Central and State Governments, Urban Local Bodies (ULBs) and Other stakeholders.
- **Key Achievements of NCAP:**
 - **24 States/UTs and 130 cities** have prepared city-specific and state-specific action plans targeting major pollution sources.
 - During **FY 2019-20 to FY 2025-26** , **₹16,423.55 crore** was provided to 130 cities through air-quality performance-linked grants, of which **₹11,575.54 crore (70.5%)** has been utilised.
 - In **FY 2025-26** , **108 cities recorded a reduction in annual PM10 concentration** compared with 2017-18 levels



Digital Tracking of Air Quality Improvement

- **PRANA Portal (Portal for Regulation of Air-Pollution in Non-Attainment Cities):** Tracks the **physical and financial progress** of NCAP implementation. It provides information on city air action plans and pollution-control activities and supports evidence-based policymaking.

Swachh Vayu Survekshan

- **About:** Launched in **2022-23** by the **Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC)**, **Swachh Vayu Survekshan** is an annual assessment of **130 NCAP cities** based on air pollution mitigation efforts.
- **Objective:** It promotes Healthy competition among cities, Innovation in pollution-control measures and Effective implementation of City-specific Clean Air Action Plans.
- **Swachh Vayu Survekshan 2026: Ward-level Swachh Vayu Survekshan** strengthens the bottom-up approach by recognising local actions for improving air quality. It was conducted across more than **7,400 wards nationwide**.
 - The **Swachh Vayu Survekshan 2026** recognised top-performing cities across three categories, with **Lucknow** securing first place in Category 1, **Rourkela** in Category 2, and **Kalinganagar** in Category 3.

What are the Sector-Wise Key Mitigation Measures Taken to Improve Air Quality?

Vehicular Emissions

- **Promotion of Cleaner Vehicles:** India introduced **BS-VI compliant vehicles** across the country from **April 2020** to significantly reduce vehicular emissions.
 - The government is promoting **electric mobility** through initiatives such as the **PM E-DRIVE scheme**

- of the Ministry of Heavy Industries and **PM E-Bus Sewa** of the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs.
- Expansion of **electric vehicle charging infrastructure** is being undertaken as per guidelines issued by the Ministry of Power.
- **Vehicle Fleet Modernisation:** The **Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH)** has established an enabling framework for the **Vehicle Scrapping Policy** through **Registered Vehicle Scrapping Facilities (RVSFs)** and **Automated Testing Stations (ATS)** .
 - The **Pollution Under Control (PUC) certification system** is being strengthened to improve compliance and monitoring of vehicle emissions.
- **Reducing Urban Transport Pollution:** City-level clean air action plans include measures such as **traffic decongestion, junction improvement and improved public transport management** to reduce emissions from vehicular movement.
 - The Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs launched **PARIVARTAN (Program for Accelerated Renewal and Incentivization of Vehicle Assets for Reducing Transport Air-Pollution and Network Emission)** to modernise transport fleets in NCR replacing **BS-IV and older trucks and buses** with BS-VI, CNG or EVs.
- **Delhi-NCR Specific Measures:** The **Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM)** has directed Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh to shift public transport, particularly buses, towards cleaner fuels. Only **BS-VI, CNG and electric buses** will be permitted to enter Delhi, including tourist buses, from **1 November 2026** .
 - CAQM has also directed faster adoption of cleaner mobility solutions by **motor vehicle aggregators, delivery service providers and e-commerce entities** .
 - Delhi and NCR districts are gradually introducing only **electric L5-category three-wheelers** for passenger and goods transport.

Industrial Emissions

- **Emission Standards and Industrial Classification:** The **Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC)** has notified sector-specific environmental standards for industries under the **Environment Protection Rules, 1986** .
 - The **Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB)** has classified **419 industrial sectors and sub-sectors** according to their pollution potential.
- **Continuous Emission Monitoring:** The CPCB has mandated **17 highly polluting industrial sectors** to install **Online Continuous Emission Monitoring Systems (OCEMS)** connected with CPCB servers for real-time compliance monitoring.
 - In Delhi-NCR, industries are required to use approved fuels and install appropriate pollution-control equipment.
- **Strengthening Industrial Compliance:** CAQM has revised particulate matter emission standards for large and polluting industries, setting a limit of **50 mg/Nm³ from 1 October 2026** .
 - State Pollution Control Boards have been directed to ensure strict monitoring and enforcement in industrial areas violating prescribed norms.
 - The **CEPI (Comprehensive Environmental Pollution Index)** framework identifies **Critically Polluted Areas (CPAs)** and **Severely Polluted Areas (SPAs)** , where targeted pollution reduction plans are implemented.
- **Power Sector Emission Control:** In **2022** , MoEFCC notified stricter **CPCB IV+ emission standards** for power generators up to **800 kW** operating on diesel, gasoline or dual fuel modes.

Road Dust and Construction Pollution

- **Dust Management at Construction Sites:** CPCB has issued guidelines for environmentally sustainable management of **Construction and Demolition (C&D) waste** and for controlling dust generated from construction activities.
 - State Pollution Control Boards and Pollution Control Committees are required to deploy **anti-smog guns and dust-control measures** at construction sites exceeding **20,000 sq. metres** .
- **Institutional Monitoring Mechanism:** Road-owning and construction agencies in NCR have been directed to establish **Dust Control and Management Cells (DCMCs)** for monitoring dust-control measures.
 - Around **70 DCMCs** have been established across NCR and are regularly reviewed by CAQM.
 - An online monitoring mechanism has been introduced for construction sites above **500 sq. metres** in Delhi-NCR.

Open Waste Burning

- **Strengthening Waste Management:** The government is implementing various waste management regulations, including:
 - [Solid Waste Management Rules, 2016 \(revised 2026\)](#) .
 - [Plastic Waste Management Rules, 2016](#) .
 - [Hazardous Waste Management Rules, 2016](#) .
 - [E-Waste Management Rules, 2022](#) .
 - [Battery Waste Management Rules, 2022](#) .
 - [Biomedical Waste Management Rules, 2016](#) .
- **Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR):** Market-based **EPR mechanisms** require producers to manage post-consumer waste such as plastic packaging, e-waste, batteries, tyres and used oil.
 - This promotes recycling, reduces landfill burden and prevents emissions from informal waste burning.
- **Plastic Waste Reduction:** India banned **12 single-use plastic items** with low utility and high littering potential, including plastic cutlery, straws and thermocol decorations, from **1st July 2022** .

Crop Residue and Biomass Burning

- **Promoting Alternative Uses of Crop Residue:** Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) provides financial assistance for establishing **paddy straw pelletisation and torrefaction plants** to promote productive utilisation of agricultural waste.
 - Under this initiative, **₹37.16 crore** has been sanctioned for **34 plants** , including **27 in Punjab and 7 in Haryana** .
- **Biomass Utilisation in Energy Sector:** CAQM has directed **5-10% biomass co-firing** in thermal power plants within 300 km of Delhi, as well as captive power plants and brick kilns in NCR, to reduce open burning of crop residue.
- **Support to Farmers:** The Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare provided **₹4,233.84 crore (2018-19 to 2025-26)** for crop residue management.
 - More than **3.53 lakh crop residue management machines** have been distributed, and **43,535 Custom Hiring Centres (CHCs)** have been established in Punjab, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Delhi.
- **Impact:** Due to coordinated efforts, paddy stubble-burning incidents declined by **93% in Punjab** and

91% in Haryana in 2025 compared with 2021 .

Afforestation and Expansion of Green Cover

- **Green India Mission:** The mission focuses on improving forest quality, enhancing ecological resilience and increasing carbon sequestration. **₹1,019.26 crore** has been released to States under the mission till **March 2026** .
- **Compensatory Afforestation:** The **Compensatory Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority (CAMPA)** supports forest restoration and ecological conservation.
 - More than **3.20 lakh hectares** of compensatory afforestation were undertaken during **FY 2020-21 to FY 2024-25** .
- **Urban Green Spaces:** The **Nagar Van Yojana (launched in 2020)** aims to develop **1,000 Nagar Vans and Vatikas by 2026-27** . As of **31st March 2026** , ₹557.62 crore has been released for developing **626 Nagar Vans/Vatikas** .
- **Landscape Restoration Initiatives:** The **Aravalli Green Wall Initiative** targets restoration of **6.31 million hectares** across Rajasthan, Gujarat, Haryana and Delhi. It has established **435 nurseries** with a capacity of **393.24 lakh seedlings** and restored around **36,025 hectares during 2025** .
- **Community Participation:** The **Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam campaign** has emerged as a mass plantation movement, with **262.4 crore saplings planted by December 2025** .

What are the Institutions Driving India's Clean Air Goals?

Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB)

- The **Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB)** is a statutory organisation established under the **Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974** and performs functions related to air pollution control under the **Air (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1981** .
- CPCB is responsible for improving air quality by undertaking **ambient air quality monitoring, formulation of pollution control standards, technical assessment and coordination with State Pollution Control Boards** .

Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM)

- The **Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM)** was established under the **Commission for Air Quality Management in National Capital Region and Adjoining Areas Act, 2021** as a dedicated statutory institution for managing air pollution in the **Delhi-NCR airshed** .
- CAQM ensures coordinated action among Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh to address regional sources of pollution that cannot be managed through isolated State-level measures.

Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP)

- The **Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP)** is an emergency response framework designed to address worsening air quality conditions in Delhi-NCR through **time-bound and progressively stricter measures** .
- GRAP is activated based on the **Air Quality Index (AQI), weather conditions and scientific assessments** to ensure timely action during periods of severe pollution.
- The plan consists of four stages:
 - **Stage I - Poor Air Quality (AQI 201-300)**
 - **Stage II - Very Poor Air Quality (AQI 301-400)**
 - **Stage III - Severe Air Quality (AQI 401-450)**
 - **Stage IV - Severe+ Air Quality (AQI above 450)**

State Pollution Control Boards (SPCBs)

- **State Pollution Control Boards (SPCBs)** are the primary regulatory institutions responsible for implementing environmental laws at the State level.
- SPCBs regulate pollution from industries by:
 - Monitoring industrial emissions.
 - Granting environmental consents.
 - Ensuring compliance with prescribed emission standards.
 - Taking enforcement action against violating industries.
- Their responsibilities have expanded beyond the **Water Act, Air Act and Environment Protection Act** to include monitoring of **noise pollution, hazardous waste, plastic waste and other environmental concerns** .

Strengthening Environmental Regulation through Digital Reforms

- To improve transparency, consistency and efficiency in environmental regulation, the Government amended the **Air (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1981** and the **Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974** .
- The Government notified:
 - **Control of Air Pollution (Grant, Refusal or Cancellation of Consent) Guidelines, 2025** on **29th January 2025** .
 - **Water Pollution (Grant, Refusal or Cancellation of Consent) Guidelines, 2025** on **30th January 2025** .
- The **Unified Consent and Authorization Management System (UCAMS)** developed by CPCB provides an online platform for processing consent applications by SPCBs and Pollution Control Committees.
- UCAMS enables **end-to-end digital processing of consent approval, refusal and cancellation** , ensuring greater **uniformity in procedures, transparency in decision-making and better compliance monitoring** .

Conclusion

India's journey towards **blue skies** requires sustained, science-based and collaborative action. Through programmes such as **NCAP**, strengthened monitoring systems, cleaner technologies and ecosystem restoration, India is moving towards healthier air and sustainable development. Continued cooperation among governments, industries and citizens will be crucial to achieving long-term air-quality improvement and building environmentally resilient communities.

Drishti Mains Practice Questions

"Air pollution in India is not merely an environmental issue but a multidimensional challenge affecting public health, economy and sustainable development." Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. What is the International Day of Clean Air for Blue Skies?

Observed on **7 September** every year and designated by the **United Nations General Assembly in 2019** to promote global awareness and action against air pollution; India observes it as **Swachh Vayu Diwas**.

Q2. What is the National Clean Air Programme (NCAP)?

Launched in **2019**, NCAP is a mission-mode programme covering **130 cities** that aims to reduce air pollution through **city-specific clean air action plans, source-based interventions, improved monitoring and institutional coordination**.

Q3. What is the difference between PM2.5 and PM10?

PM10 consists of particles with a diameter of **10 micrometres or less**, while **PM2.5** consists of finer particles of **2.5 micrometres or less** that can penetrate deep into lungs and even enter the bloodstream, posing greater health risks.

Q4. What is AQI?

Air Quality Index (AQI) is a public communication tool that categorises air quality based on concentrations of **eight pollutants — PM2.5, PM10, NO₂, SO₂, CO, O₃, NH₃ and Lead (Pb)** and their associated health impacts.

Q5. What is the PRANA Portal?

PRANA (Portal for Regulation of Air-Pollution in Non-Attainment Cities) is a digital platform that tracks the **physical and financial progress of NCAP implementation** and provides information on air-quality management activities.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/VZWArzmaQc](https://www.youtube.com/embed/VZWArzmaQc)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. Artificial way of causing rainfall to reduce air pollution makes use of (2025)

- a) silver iodide and potassium iodide
- b) silver nitrate and potassium iodide
- c) silver iodide and potassium nitrate
- d) silver nitrate and potassium chloride

Ans: (a)

Q. How is the National Green Tribunal (NGT) different from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB)? (2018)

1. The NGT has been established by an Act whereas the CPCB has been created by an executive order of the Government.
2. The NGT provides environmental justice and helps reduce the burden of litigation in the higher courts whereas the CPCB promotes cleanliness of streams and wells, and aims to improve the quality of air in the country.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. Describe the key points of the revised Global Air Quality Guidelines (AQGs) recently released by the World Health Organisation (WHO). How are these different from its last update in 2005? What changes in India's National Clean Air Programme are required to achieve revised standards? (2021)

1st-Ever District-Level Estimates for the Unincorporated Non-Agricultural Sector



Source: PIB

The **National Statistical Office (NSO)** under the **Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI)** released the **1 st -ever district-level estimates for India's unincorporated non-agricultural sector**, based on data from the **Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE) 2025** .

- **Significance for Governance:** High-frequency, district-level data is essential for addressing regional economic imbalances and crafting targeted interventions for MSME formalization, micro-credit access, and women's economic empowerment under India's federal planning architecture.

Key Highlights of the District-Level Estimates

- **Unprecedented Granularity:** The **first District-Level Estimates** are available for **757 of 770 districts** , providing granular data to strengthen **sub-state statistics** and support **evidence-based, localised policymaking** .
- **Geographical Concentration:** The top 10 districts (located across Gujarat, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh, and West Bengal) generate about **10% of the country's unincorporated establishments**, workers, and **Gross Value Added (GVA)**.
 - The top 50 districts account for **nearly one-third of the sector's total establishments and workforce**.
 - Only 16 districts have over 5 lakh establishments, with half of them (8) located in West Bengal.
- **Productivity Disparities (GVA per Worker):** Gross Value Added (GVA) per worker acts as a proxy for economic productivity.
 - The all-India average **GVA per worker stands at Rs 1,56,539**. In 280 districts, productivity exceeds the national average, while 331 districts fall slightly below it (between Rs 1 lakh and Rs 1.5 lakh).
- **Women's Participation & Entrepreneurship:** In 237 districts, women constitute at least one-third of the total unincorporated workforce. In 25 districts, they make up more than 50% of the workforce.
 - The states with the highest share of female-led unincorporated establishments are **Telangana, Manipur, Meghalaya, and Mizoram**.
 - In Mizoram, female-owned proprietary establishments account for at least 50% in every single district.

Read more: [Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises \(ASUSE\) 2026](#)